

Persecution and Afflictions

Open where we left off, in Mark 4. We will begin again tonight with verse 9.

We have been uncovering the smokescreen tactics of the devil, and we found out his most valuable tool is deceit. We have power over all the power of the enemy. Since he has no more power than we do, because we have power over all of his power, his most valuable weapon is deceit. He is so limited that he must deceive you into accepting your own defeat.

We have been exploring some of his tactics. He is a military genius. He has studied us for six thousand years. If anybody knows what motivates us through the flesh, it is the devil.

The most powerful position the devil can take in your life is one where he can continually affect your thinking and yet remain undetected. The biggest smokescreen he owns is religion. If he can get you to believe that what is not God is God, then the light in you becomes darkness, and great is that darkness, because your power goes with it.

No wonder we want to uncover some of his smokescreens.

Mark 4:9 says:

And he said unto them,
He that hath ears to hear,
let him hear.

Thank God for that. The Holy Spirit said that tonight. God said that tonight.

He who has ears to hear, let him hear. He was warning you tonight: tune up. This is not one of those messages where you think, "I will tune out and come back for the miracles." If you are going to tune out, then you are losing your ears to hear.

Tune out, go to sleep, make yourself comfortable, and rest. We love you. We will wake you up when the miracles take place. Later on you can get your friends to whip the devil for you.

He who has ears to hear, let him hear.

And when he was alone,
they that were about him with the twelve
asked of him the parable.
And he said unto them,
Unto you it is given to know the mystery of the kingdom of God:
but unto them that are without,
all these things are done in parables:
That seeing they may see,
and not perceive;
and hearing they may hear,
and not understand;
lest at any time they should be converted,
and their sin should be forgiven them.

Then after that statement He said:

Know ye not this parable?
and how then will ye know all parables?

The mysteries of the kingdom are given to you to understand. If you do not know the simple parable of the sower, what basis do you have to understand any other parable He taught?

For those who were not here last night, the verse about seeing and not perceiving, hearing and not understanding, goes back to the third chapter.

In Mark 3, Jesus' kinsmen, His relatives, came to take Him away and put Him in a mental institution. They were calling Him off. King James says, "He is beside Himself," which means they thought He was mad.

Then the scribes chimed in and said, "He has a devil."

Here He was, working miracles and casting out devils by the precious power of the Holy Spirit. Their hearts were so hardened, as Isaiah prophesied, that they said the very presence of God, the Holy Ghost, was an unclean spirit.

Because of this, they brought judgment on themselves. Jesus called them and said, "If Satan casts out Satan, his kingdom is divided. How shall it stand? If I am casting the devil out by the Holy Spirit, then the kingdom of God is in your midst and the Holy Spirit is doing these miracles."

Furthermore, He said, "You can blaspheme God. You can blaspheme Me. But when you call the Holy Spirit an unclean spirit, you are committing the unpardonable sin, you hard-hearted bunch Isaiah prophesied about. You have already turned God against you."

So when He preached, He preached in parables because of the judgment that had come on the Pharisees, lest they would hear and understand when judgment had already been passed on them because of the hardness of their hearts.

Jesus went on to say, "Do you not know this parable? The mysteries are given to you to understand."

If you do not understand how the Word of God is sown in the human heart, and if you do not understand how to guard against these five things that enter in to destroy the Word, what basis do you have to understand any other parable He taught?

Those five things are persecutions, afflictions, cares of this life, deceitfulness of riches, and lusts of other things. Guarding against them allows the Word to grow and produce a hundredfold.

The understanding of the function of the Word is the key to understanding any other parable. Once I understood the parable of the sower, other parables started opening up, just as the Spirit had spoken: the ten virgins, five wise and five foolish; the treasure hidden in the field; the pearl of great price. It was amazing to see the mysteries contained within those parables.

I felt like I had sat down at a big feast fit for a king and eaten until the buttons on my coat started killing people across the table.

I found out in the parable of the ten virgins that the oil in the lamp was not the Holy Ghost. I have news for you: you cannot put Him out. The devil already found that out. You cannot put Jesus out. You cannot put the Holy Ghost out. He will not go out.

The oil that went out was revelation knowledge. The wick that drew that oil and fed the flame is the tongue, the tongue that draws out illumination and authority to light your path so you can walk in this natural world.

Jesus said:

Know ye not this parable?
and how then will ye know all parables?

Then He gave the subject:

The sower soweth the word.

The subject is the Word. The objective is how to take the Word of God and turn a hundredfold.

Every parable has an objective. This one is to turn a hundredfold while walking on the Word of God.

If the subject is "the sower soweth the Word," then verse 21 belongs to that subject:

Is a candle brought to be put under a bushel,
or under a bed?
and not to be set on a candlestick?

In other words, what is the Word of God given to you for? Is the Word of God given to you not to understand? Or is it given like a candle, to illuminate you so you can walk by the light of it?

The Word is not given to you to remain hidden. To you and me, it has been given to understand the mysteries of the kingdom.

Now He uncovers the first two forces the devil uses as a smokescreen. Verse 15 says:

And these are they by the way side,
where the word is sown;
but when they have heard,
Satan cometh immediately,
and taketh away the word that was sown in their hearts.

Satan comes immediately. How soon is that? A while ago. It has already passed.

That little devil some of you brought in, sitting on your shoulder, said, "Not true, not true, not true," before you even knew what was being said. He likes to prepare you ahead of time.

Who comes? Satan. He comes immediately. Notice what he is after: the Word sown in their hearts.

As much talent as I have, as good as I can sing, and as good-looking as I am, those are not the things he is after. He is after the Word in me because he knows the longer he leaves that Word in, the more danger he runs of me rising up one day and destroying a major portion of his kingdom.

If there is anything he is deathly afraid of, it is that one day you will grab hold of the Word of God and start making it work.

Immediately upon the sowing of the Word, upon any new revelation, Satan comes to remove the Word of God sown in your hearts.

Let us examine two forces he uses to take the Word out. Verse 16 says:

And these are they likewise which are sown on stony ground;
who, when they have heard the word,
immediately receive it with gladness;
And have no root in themselves,
and so endure but for a time:
afterward,
when affliction or persecution ariseth for the word's sake,
immediately they are offended.

The word "likewise" means that just as Satan came to the first group, he comes to the second. Only now Jesus reveals two of his forces: persecution and afflictions.

These are they that have no root in themselves. They almost sprang up overnight.

Have you ever seen someone get born again, particularly someone who has a lot of talent, and the pastor makes a big mistake? Somebody famous in the world gets born again, and immediately they say, "Would you come up here and sing for us?"

Suddenly that person has a national ministry, in a sense. They are known all over. Their fame just switches from the world to the church world. It looks like God did a fast work in their life. They sprang up and grew.

I have news for you. It was not God who exalted them. He will no more exalt them that way than He will exalt you. The problem with their growth rate is that now they are in the public limelight. Everybody is looking at them. They sprang up overnight.

Then two or three weeks later they are down in the corner bar. What happened? The same forces worked against them that work against you. Only they were in the spotlight.

It did not mean they had more grace from God, more power from God, or were any stronger than you are. When these things entered in, it just became more public. Satan came immediately with persecution and afflictions and convinced them the Word did not work.

The moment he did that, he was able to scorch it, destroy the root, and remove it from their life. Nine times out of ten, they will turn to a doctrine the devil created that wallows in a safe zone of the flesh.

Let me tell you one thing: that is not going to help you in the end time. You are going to need your faith. You are going to be glad for people like us and cities like Tulsa.

Persecution and afflictions arise for one reason: to remove the Word of God planted in your heart.

Peter says:

Think it not strange concerning the fiery trial which is to try you,
as though some strange thing happened unto you.

We get to thinking it is strange. After a while we think, "My God, what did I ever do to deserve this? I have served God faithfully. I have tithed. I was never sick a day in my life until I started confessing this stuff. Then all of a sudden somebody opened the doors of hell."

About that time, here comes another doctrine:

"God put that on you to teach you something."

"Well, He must have, because it is certainly not my fault."

Have you ever felt that way? You may not have told anybody, but you thought, "I am being persecuted. I have it worse than anybody. If you only knew my troubles. I do not want to say anything, but could you give me a little sympathy?"

Where is the local pity party?

We drag in, and we pray the place we drag into has strong Christians, so they will not say, "Oh, you poor little thing." Instead, they will say, "Let us start praying in the Holy Ghost. Let us start quoting the Word of God, that very Word he is trying to take out of you. You are on the verge of producing something. This is not the time to give up. Take your stand stronger. Pray in the Holy Ghost until the image of that promise gets stronger than the image lodged in your mind."

And you win.

It is easy to think it strange, especially when it is happening to you. What did you do? You received the Word of God of a greater victory in Jesus Christ.

Whether on a world scale, international scale, national scale, state scale, city scale, county scale, or right down to your personal life, all persecutions and afflictions arise for one reason: to take the Word of God out of the heart of the one who possesses it.

James said:

Let no man say when he is tempted,
I am tempted of God:
for God cannot be tempted with evil,
neither tempteth he any man.

The word "tempted" in the Greek is interchangeable with testing and trial. James says no man can say when he is tempted, tested, or tried that he is tempted, tested, or tried by God. God cannot be tempted, tested, or tried with evil, and neither does He tempt, test, or try any man with evil.

If that does not make it plain enough, I do not know what does.

If I stand before Jesus and God says, "I sent that stuff into your life to make you stronger," and it neutralized me and caused me to go to hell, then I would make Him stand accountable for me being in hell.

But He is not the author of that. He said no man can say it, because God cannot be tested with that stuff, neither will He test you with it.

He has His own proving methods. I will grant you, He will prove your faith. That is different from being tested with evil. He will prove to you how good faith works by leading you into a situation just a little bit over your head. Then you get an opportunity to use your faith, but it will be for victory, not some damnable disease.

Hallelujah. I love it.

Persecution means to pursue relentlessly over a cause. Satan, through persecution, pursues you relentlessly to remove the very thing from your heart that he fears so deathly: the Word of God.

At the same time he is pressuring you and pursuing you, he will begin to give you alternatives. Have you ever noticed that?

"Just lay down and die."

That is an alternative.

How dare you let a terminal disease kill you? Who told you your work here is done?

"I cannot stop it."

Maybe not right now. But He has made available to you the very tools you need to stop it. First, you need to transform your mind. You need to quit thinking stupid.

Persecution pursues relentlessly through any means to remove the Word. It can be job losses, being thrown in jail, or being picked up on a speeding ticket while you are standing there in righteousness with a bunch of sinners. Those things are mild. Communism could take your country over, throw you in prison, and beat you with whips day after day to get you to deny Jesus.

That is persecution: to pursue relentlessly to remove the Word of God out of your heart.

Affliction carries a whole scope. It means to oppress, to weigh down with anything that will weigh you down. It covers disease and any other force Satan can conjure up. Any kind of damnable disease you want to name is covered under afflictions.

He will weigh you down with it, using that very force to convince you that the Word is not all those faith preachers crack it up to be. That is why he brings it.

When I first launched the ministry and God started using me in miracles, I was doing a Full Gospel Businessmen's dinner. A woman who was deaf in one ear was sitting in front of me, and I picked it up in the Spirit.

I said, "Ma'am, would you come over here? I want to pray for you."

She got up and said, "What is really wrong with me is my hip. I cannot lift it over this high."

I said, "We will pray for that, but first we will pray for your ears."

It happened that the devil was a deaf spirit. I reached my hand up to pray for that ear, and before I got within six inches, that ear opened perfectly and the other side went deaf. That thing went right through her brain and got in the other one.

So I put my hand on the other side, and it went over to the first one. I thought, "I am going to get you." I put both hands on her ears, her ears popped open, and she said, "Oh my God, I can hear out of both ears. I can really hear."

I said, "Certainly."

Now we were in the place where we were using the Word of God in us for the benefit of others. Thank God, I am not wrapped up in me anymore.

We set her in a chair because she could not lift her leg. I prayed, one leg lengthened way out, and the hip popped loose. She stood up and lifted her leg as high as she could. She looked at me in utter amazement.

She said, "But you do not understand. The doctor said it was fused."

I said, "Yes, ma'am, I understand."

"No, you do not understand. I could not lift it."

"I understand. God did a miracle."

"But you do not understand. The doctor said..."

"Ma'am, I do understand."

A month later, when we came back to her city, she came to the crusade. She tried to get into the Word. I believe she was a Catholic lady. She got some of our tapes and began getting into the Word.

She came back to the monthly meeting and said, "My ear went deaf again."

I said, "I know what that is." I rebuked it, and it came out.

Then it went deaf again, so I rebuked it and it came out.

It was the town where Tim McFall lived. Two weeks later, this lady had a heart attack and was sent to the hospital. Tim went in and prayed for her, and she was healed.

Finally, months later, she came back sicker than she had ever been. She said, "Before I met you, all I had was a deaf ear and a partially disabled hip. Now the only thing that does not hurt is the hip. Everything else is wrong."

So I took her into the Word of God and said, "Look why Satan has come. I told you how to stand him off. He has come with persecutions and afflictions. Can you see?"

I took hours to talk her into it. She said, "Yes, okay."

That night she was fellowshiping in the fellowship room. When she left, she fell off the porch and broke herself up. I did not see her again for about a year. I happened to drop in on a friend's prayer meeting, and this lady was in the prayer meeting. When I came in, she left.

Persecutions and afflictions arise for one reason.

Then there was a lady in a coma. Her relatives who were born again said, "Brother Roberson, would you please come over and pray for this woman?"

All her relatives had flown in for the funeral. She only had a matter of hours to live. She was in a deep coma, and her lungs were full of cancer clusters. She was full of it.

I was as surprised as anybody. I walked in, and everybody was waiting around for her to die.

I said, "Would you get out of this room? Get out of this room."

I cleared the room, went in, and leaned over her. All of a sudden that bold kind of authority came on me. If I ever felt sorry for the devil, it was then.

I grabbed hold of that woman, and if there were any devils left in her, it was because they were dead. The Spirit of God said, "She will come to within thirty minutes, and she is going to be hungry."

Boy, they heard me. All those sinners heard me yelling at the devil and praying in tongues.

When I came out of the room, I had a swath at least fifteen feet wide to walk through. I walked to the door, turned around, and they were all gawking at me.

I said, "She is going to wake up in thirty minutes, and she is going to be hungry. Fix her something to eat."

They just looked at me, stunned. I closed the door.

This woman came running over and grabbed hold of me later. She said, "She came walking out of the room within thirty minutes. We were all in such shock that she sat down and devoured a whole bowl of chips we had out for the guests."

Immediately she and her daughter started coming to our Word center, even though they belonged to a form of godliness that denied the power. They started coming, but she could not break away from the form. There were tears on the altar. Her mother and father were in it. She could not break away. She was steeped in the tradition of that form of godliness.

A definite fear had been engrafted into her that if she ever left the church, she would end up in hell. She tried to come and tried to come, but could not. She fell away.

Approximately seven or eight months later, the same disease came on her, and it progressed at seven times the speed until she was dead.

That is what Jesus said:

When the unclean spirit is gone out of a man,
he walketh through dry places,
seeking rest;
and finding none,
he saith,
I will return unto my house whence I came out.
And when he cometh,
he findeth it swept and garnished.
Then goeth he,
and taketh to him seven other spirits more wicked than himself;
and they enter in,
and dwell there:
and the last state of that man is worse than the first.

I asked Jesus what the swept and garnished house meant. He brought me further into that chapter, where a woman cried with a loud voice:

Blessed is the womb that bare thee,
and the paps which thou hast sucked.

Jesus said:

Yea rather,
blessed are they that hear the word of God,
and keep it.

Why are they more blessed? Even in Jesus' day, that spirit was trying to turn worship to His mother. He said, "No, more blessed are they who hear the Word and keep it."

When that devil comes back with his cohorts and finds them still swept and garnished from the disease, but void of the Word, they have nothing to stop him with. He will come back and progress at seven times the speed, unless you have enough Word to hold him.

Why, out of all the things Satan could remove out of you, does he major on the Word of God? Because he runs the risk of you believing it and producing up to one hundred times the speed of the Word of God.